



SWEET DREAMS

Passengers on the Martin 130 Clipper flights across the Pacific had access to sleeping berths. However, Pan American built hotels at island stopover points along the route, so that travelers could have a good night's rest away from the drone of the engines and constant vibration.

of land-plane, flying boat, and train travel, but in 1937, Britain's Imperial Airways introduced the Short Empire flying boats, which flew the Southampton to Sydney, Australia, and Cape Town, South Africa, routes in stages.

Image of luxury

The Empire boats rivaled the American clippers for luxury. Passengers could recline in a spacious cabin filled with the rich smell of leather upholstery, as stewards recruited from the Cunard shipping line served lobster and caviar. Or they might stand at the windows of the observation deck taking in the panoramic views of exotic landscapes passing a few thousand feet below. Passengers on

the Africa route were issued with guidebooks that suggested sights to look out for, including places where basking crocodiles or herds of elephant were to be seen. Some of the stops along the way

were in remote locations, bringing encounters with exotic animals and mud-hut-dwelling villagers.

There was no denying the glamour of the image of flying-boat travel. Pan American's Pacific passenger operation, for example, was an unashamedly exclusive service, with a round ticket from San Francisco to Manila costing over \$1,400 – about equal to an average American worker's annual pay. The Pacific flying boats were even given the accolade of Hollywood treatment, with the release of the movie *China Clipper* starring Humphrey Bogart as a flying-boat pilot.

But the intended luxury of flying-boat travel was never quite matched by performance. Like 1930s land-planes, none of them was pressurized, and so they often flew through weather that made passengers airsick. Speeds were very slow, making journeys long and grueling – the Empire flying boats took nine days from London to Sydney. The overnight stops at hotels did not necessarily help much, especially since passengers were usually required to board in the early hours of the morning, when cool conditions were ideal for

